Chandra Chatterjee. They met at Kanpur in October 1924 and vowed to overthrow colonial rule and establish a federated democratic India. On 9 August 1925 in a nondescript village by the name of Kakori near Lucknow, ten men set upon the Number 8 Down Train and ransacked the official treasury of the railway. They were all quickly arrested. Government retribution was swift and harsh—five of them were hanged, including Ashfaqullah Khan, Ram Prasad Bismil, Roshan Singh and Rajendra Lahiri. Four were destined for life in the gruelling conditions of the Andaman Islands. One such was Mahavir Singh, who was to emerge again later. Long years of imprisonment awaited seventeen others. Remarkably, Chandrashekhar Azad escaped. With strategic acumen, Bhagat Singh saw an opportunity to revitalize the revolutionary movement. So in 1926 came into prominence the Naujawan Bharat Sabha to bring the youth under one socialist non-religious banner with its 'proselytising thrust against communal politics . . .'.[4]

Bhagat Singh had to take such drastic action because the defeat of the plotters in the Kakori Conspiracy Case of 1925 had decapitated India's insurrectionary forces. Ram Prasad Bismil and Ashfaqullah Khan, the trailblazers in the vanguard of that short-lived movement, were no more. At a stroke the leadership of India's revolutionary movement had been destroyed, calling for a new breed of rebel leaders. Leaders who would resurrect the revolutionary movement from its ashes and give it renewed life and sustenance. Bhagat Singh had imbibed from the Arya Samajist and Ghadarite traditions of his staunchly militant family. As a boy aged twelve, he had recoiled in revulsion at the cold-blooded killing of hundreds of innocents by General Dyer in the Jallianwala Bagh Massacre of 1919 in Amritsar. Alongside many others at the time, he had joined Mahatma Gandhi's non-cooperation struggle. But the Mahatma had soon abandoned this campaign. Like many others, Bhagat Singh had become disillusioned with the Mahatma. His establishment in 1926 of the Naujawan Bharat Sabha became an eerie prologue to the later formation of the Hindustan Socialist Republican Association in 1928 on the dead bones of the Hindustan Republican Association, whose derisory record had been such